WEJ LAB

Cross Validation

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Learning objectives

By the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- Explain over-training and over-smoothing using kNN
- Describe K-fold cross-validation and the bootstrap
- Use cross-validation to choose a tuning parameter
- Fit and tune models with caret's `train` function

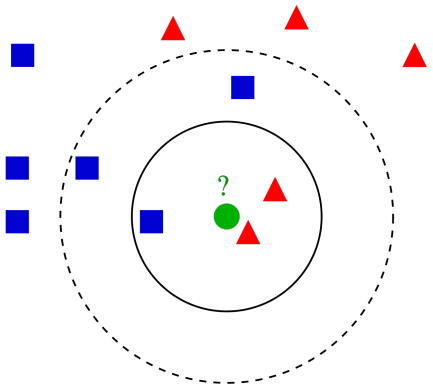
Cross-validation

Cross-validation is one of the most important ideas in machine learning. We start with the concepts and math, then implement it with `caret`.

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K-nearest neighbors (kNN)

To motivate cross-validation, we start with a real algorithm: **k-nearest neighbors (kNN)**.



K-nearest neighbors (kNN)

K-nearest neighbor algorithm pseudocode

Programming languages like Python and R are used to implement the KNN algorithm. The following is the pseudocode for KNN:

1. Load the data
2. Choose K value
3. For each data point in the data:
    - Find the Euclidean distance to all training data samples
    - Store the distances on an ordered list and sort it
    - Choose the top K entries from the sorted list
    - Label the test point based on the majority of classes present in the selected points
4. End

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K-nearest neighbors (kNN)

kNN estimates the conditional probability

$$p(x_1, x_2) = \Pr(Y = 1 \mid X_1 = x_1, X_2 = x_2).$$

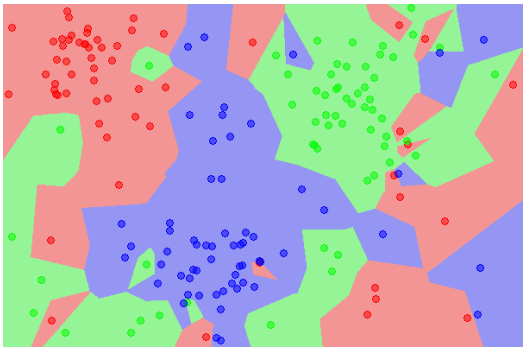
For any point (x_1, x_2):

1. Find the k nearest training points (the *neighborhood*)
2. Average their 0s and 1s to get $\hat{p}(x_1, x_2)$

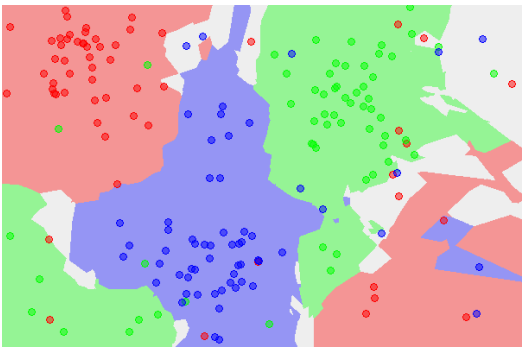
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K-nearest neighbors (kNN)

Using $k=1$:



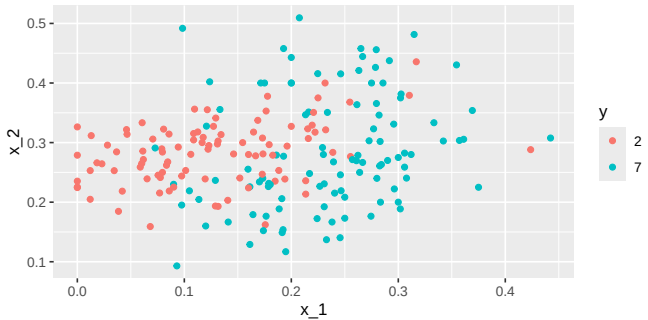
and $k=5$:



K-nearest neighbors (kNN): Example

Using the following dataset:

```
library(dslabs); data("mnist_27")
mnist_27$test %>% ggplot(aes(x_1, x_2, color = y)) + geom_point()
```



K-nearest neighbors (kNN): Example

Fit kNN with $k = 5$ using `caret::knn3`:

```
library(caret)
knn_fit <- knn3(y ~ ., data = mnist_27$train, k = 5)
```

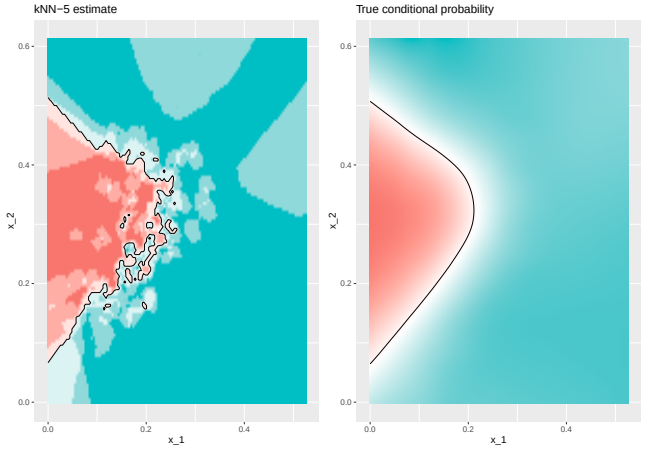
K-nearest neighbors (kNN): Example

The classes are balanced, so we use accuracy to measure performance. `type = "class"` returns predicted labels:

```
y_hat_knn <- predict(knn_fit, mnist_27$test, type = "class")
confusionMatrix(y_hat_knn, mnist_27$test$y)$overall["Accuracy"]
```

```
## Accuracy
##    0.815
```

K-nearest neighbors (kNN): Example



Over-training

Over-training (over-fitting): accuracy is higher on the training set than on the test set:

```
y_hat_knn <- predict(knn_fit, mnist_27$train, type = "class")
confusionMatrix(y_hat_knn, mnist_27$train$y)$overall["Accuracy"]
```

```
## Accuracy
##   0.8575
```

```
y_hat_knn <- predict(knn_fit, mnist_27$test, type = "class")
confusionMatrix(y_hat_knn, mnist_27$test$y)$overall["Accuracy"]
```

```
## Accuracy
##    0.815
```

Over-training

Over-training is worst with $k = 1$:

```
knn_fit_1 <- knn3(y ~ ., data = mnist_27$train, k = 1)
y_hat_knn_1 <- predict(knn_fit_1, mnist_27$train, type = "class")
confusionMatrix(y_hat_knn_1, mnist_27$train$y)$overall[["Accuracy"]]
```

```
## [1] 0.995
```

```
y_hat_knn_1 <- predict(knn_fit_1, mnist_27$test, type = "class")
confusionMatrix(y_hat_knn_1, mnist_27$test$y)$overall["Accuracy"]
```

```
## Accuracy
##     0.81
```

Over-training

With $k = 1$, the boundary traces every training point:



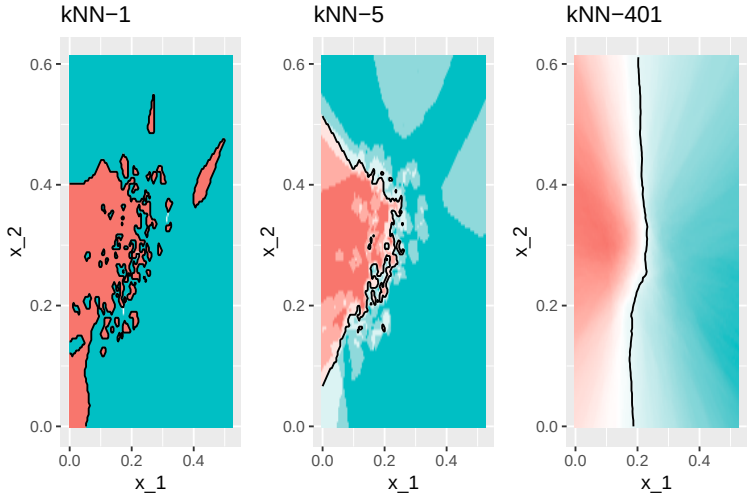
Over-smoothing

$k = 5$ is also over-trained, though less than $k = 1$. What about a much larger k, such as $k = 401$?

```
knn_fit_401 <- knn3(y ~ ., data = mnist_27$train, k = 401)
y_hat_knn_401 <- predict(knn_fit_401, mnist_27$test,
                         type = "class")
confusionMatrix(y_hat_knn_401, mnist_27$test$y)$overall["Accuracy"]
```

```
## Accuracy
##     0.76
```

Over-smoothing



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Picking the k in kNN

We want the k that maximizes accuracy (or minimizes expected MSE). **Cross validation** estimates these quantities for any algorithm and tuning parameter.

To see why we need it, try many values of k:

```
ks <- seq(3, 251, 2)
```

Picking the k in kNN

Use `map_df` to compute train and test accuracy for each k:

```
library(purrr)
accuracy <- map_df(ks, function(k){
  fit <- knn3(y ~ ., data = mnist_27$train, k = k)

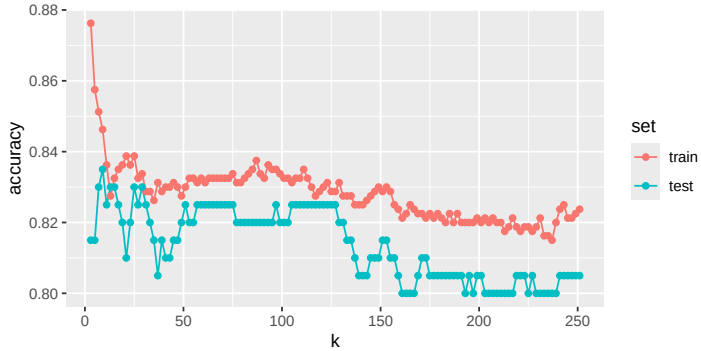
  y_hat <- predict(fit, mnist_27$train, type = "class")
  cm_train <- confusionMatrix(y_hat, mnist_27$train$y)
  train_error <- cm_train$overall["Accuracy"]

  y_hat <- predict(fit, mnist_27$test, type = "class")
  cm_test <- confusionMatrix(y_hat, mnist_27$test$y)
  test_error <- cm_test$overall["Accuracy"]

  tibble(train = train_error, test = test_error)
})
```

Picking the k in kNN

Accuracy for each k:



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Picking the k in kNN

Picking k this way uses the test set, so this accuracy is over-optimistic:

```
ks[which.max(accuracy$test)]
```

```
## [1] 9
```

```
max(accuracy$test)
```

```
## [1] 0.835
```

Mathematical description of cross validation

Goal: find predictions $\hat{Y}$ for outcome Y that minimize the MSE:

$$\text{MSE} = \text{E}\left\{\frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}(\hat{Y}_i - Y_i)^2\right\}$$

Mathematical description of cross validation

With only one dataset, we estimate it with the observed MSE:

$$\hat{\text{MSE}} = \frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}(\hat{y}_i - y_i)^2$$

These are the *true error* and the *apparent error*.

Mathematical description of cross validation

Two problems with the apparent error:

1. It is a random variable: one algorithm can beat another by luck.
2. If we train and evaluate on the same data, we overtrain (as with $k = 1$).

Mathematical description of cross validation

Cross validation addresses both. Think of the true error as the average apparent error over B new random samples, none used for training:

$$\frac{1}{B}\sum_{b=1}^{B}\frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\left(\hat{y}_i^b - y_i^b\right)^2$$

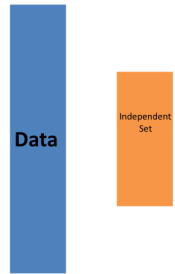
with B practically infinite.

Mathematical description of cross validation

In practice we only have one set of outcomes, $y_1, \ldots, y_n$. Cross validation imitates this setup by generating many random samples from the data we have.

K-fold cross validation

We start with a dataset (blue) and want an algorithm that works on independent validation data (yellow).



K-fold cross validation

But we never see the independent data.



K-fold cross validation

So we split off a **training set** (blue) and a **test set** (red). Train only on the training set; use the test set only for evaluation.



K-fold cross validation

We need to tune parameters (λ) without touching the test set, and tuning and evaluating on the same data overtrains.

Cross validation estimates the MSE for each candidate λ; we pick the smallest.

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K-fold cross validation

For a fixed λ, we want to imitate

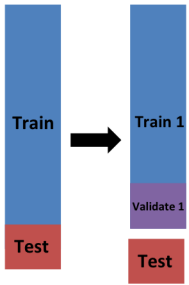
$$\text{MSE}(\lambda) = \frac{1}{B}\sum_{b=1}^{B}\frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N}\left(\hat{y}_i^b(\lambda) - y_i^b\right)^2$$

K-fold cross validation creates K pseudo-independent samples. Here $K = 5$.

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K-fold cross validation

Pick $M = N/K$ observations at random as the *validation set* $y_1^b, \ldots, y_M^b$ (here $b = 1$):



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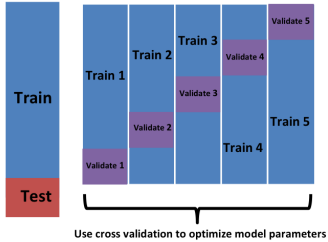
K-fold cross validation

Fit on the rest of the training set, then compute the error on the validation set:

$$\hat{\mathrm{MSE}}_b(\lambda) = \frac{1}{M} \sum_{i=1}^{M} \left(\hat{y}_i^b(\lambda) - y_i^b \right)^2$$

K-fold cross validation

Split the observations into K non-overlapping folds:



K-fold cross validation

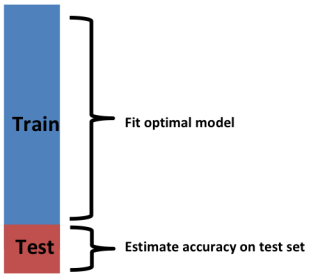
Repeat for each fold $b = 1, \ldots, K$ and average:

$$\hat{\text{MSE}}(\lambda) = \frac{1}{K} \sum_{b=1}^{K} \hat{\text{MSE}}_b(\lambda)$$

Then pick the λ that minimizes $\hat{\text{MSE}}(\lambda)$.

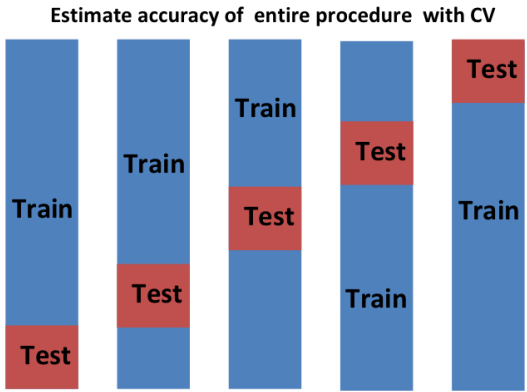
K-fold cross validation

Tuning used the training data, so evaluate the final model on the test set:

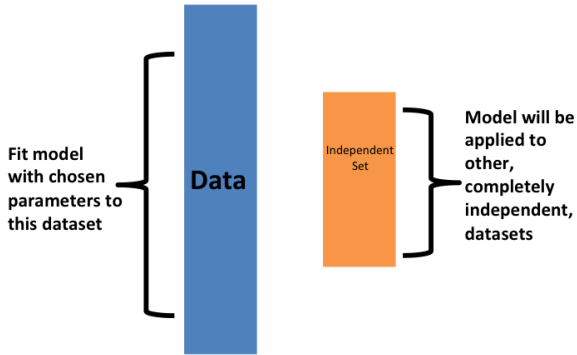


K-fold cross validation

Or cross validate the whole procedure again:



K-fold cross validation



K-fold cross validation

Choosing K:

- Larger K: training folds look more like the full data
- But slower: 100-fold is 10x slower than 10-fold
- $K = 5$ and $K = 10$ are popular choices

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K-fold cross validation

To reduce variance, we can take more samples: pick sets of observations at random instead of fixed folds.

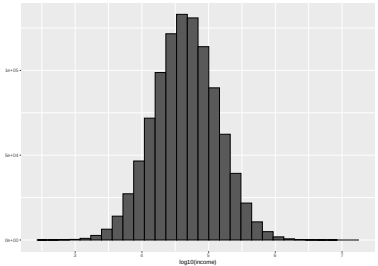
Sampling **with replacement** is the *bootstrap*, and it is the default in **caret**. Here is how the bootstrap works in general.

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Bootstrap

Suppose the income distribution of your population is as follows:

```
set.seed(1995)
n <- 10^6
income <- 10^(rnorm(n, log10(45000), log10(3)))
qplot(log10(income), bins = 30, color = I("black"))
```



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Bootstrap

The population median is:

```
m <- median(income)
m
```

```
## [1] 44938.54
```

Bootstrap

In practice we only have a sample. Estimate m with the median M of a sample of 100:

```
N <- 100
X <- sample(income, N)
median(X)
```

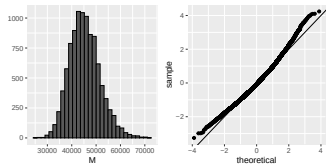
```
## [1] 38461.33
```

How to construct a CI? What is the distribution of M?

Bootstrap

We can use a Monte Carlo simulation to learn the distribution of M.

```
library(gridExtra)
B <- 10^4
M <- replicate(B, {X <- sample(income, N); median(X)})
p1 <- qplot(M, bins = 30, color = I("black"))
p2 <- qplot(sample = scale(M), xlab = "theoretical",
            ylab = "sample") + geom_abline()
grid.arrange(p1, p2, ncol = 2)
```



Bootstrap

In practice we don't know this distribution. A 95% CI based on the CLT:

```
median(X) + 1.96 * sd(X) / sqrt(N) * c(-1, 1)
```

```
## [1] 21017.93 55904.72
```

Bootstrap

is quite different from the CI from the actual distribution of M:

```
quantile(M, c(0.025, 0.975))
```

```
##      2.5%    97.5%
## 34437.72 59049.59
```

Bootstrap

Bootstrap: resample X with replacement to approximate the distribution of M:

```
B <- 10^4
M_star <- replicate(B, {
  X_star <- sample(X, N, replace = TRUE)
  median(X_star)
})
```

The bootstrap CI is much closer to the true one:

```
quantile(M_star, c(0.025, 0.975))
```

```
##     2.5%    97.5%
## 30252.82 56908.62
```

Bootstrap

For more, including bias corrections for bootstrap CIs, see Efron & Tibshirani, *An Introduction to the Bootstrap*.

In cross validation, we can bootstrap many times instead of dividing the data into equal folds.

The caret package

Every ML package in R has its own syntax. **caret** gives one consistent interface to 237 methods[1].

caret does not install the underlying packages; the manual lists what each method needs.

[1] https://topepo.github.io/caret/available-models.html

The caret `train` function

caret can also run cross validation for us. We use the 2 or 7 example again:

```
library(tidyverse)
library(dslabs)
data("mnist_27")
```

The caret `train` function

`train` fits different algorithms with the same syntax:

```
library(caret)
train_glm <- train(y ~ ., method = "glm",
                   data = mnist_27$train)
train_knn <- train(y ~ ., method = "knn",
                   data = mnist_27$train)
```

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The caret `train` function

Prediction code is also the same for every method (`predict.train`):

```
y_hat_glm <- predict(train_glm,
                     mnist_27$test, type = "raw")
y_hat_knn <- predict(train_knn,
                     mnist_27$test, type = "raw")
```

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The caret `train` function

So comparing algorithms is quick:

```
confusionMatrix(y_hat_glm,
      mnist_27$test$y)$overall[["Accuracy"]]
```

```
## [1] 0.775
```

```
confusionMatrix(y_hat_knn,
      mnist_27$test$y)$overall[["Accuracy"]]
```

```
## [1] 0.835
```

Cross validation

For algorithms with tuning parameters, `train` automatically cross validates over a few default values. To see which parameters are tuned:

```
getModelInfo("knn")
```

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Cross validation

or the quicker:

```
modelLookup("knn")
```

Run with defaults:

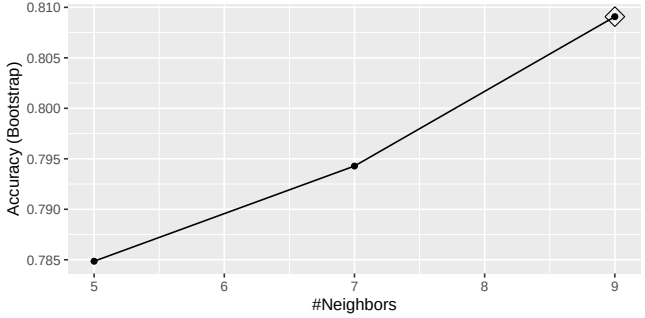
```
train_knn <- train(y ~ ., method = "knn",
                   data = mnist_27$train)
```

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Cross validation

Plot the CV results; `highlight = TRUE` marks the best:

```
ggplot(train_knn, highlight = TRUE)
```



Cross validation

Defaults: 25 bootstrap samples, and for kNN only $k = 5, 7, 9$.

Change the candidates with `tuneGrid`: a data frame whose column names match `modelLookup`.

Cross validation

Try 32 values of k from 9 to 71: `data.frame(k = seq(9, 71, 2))`.

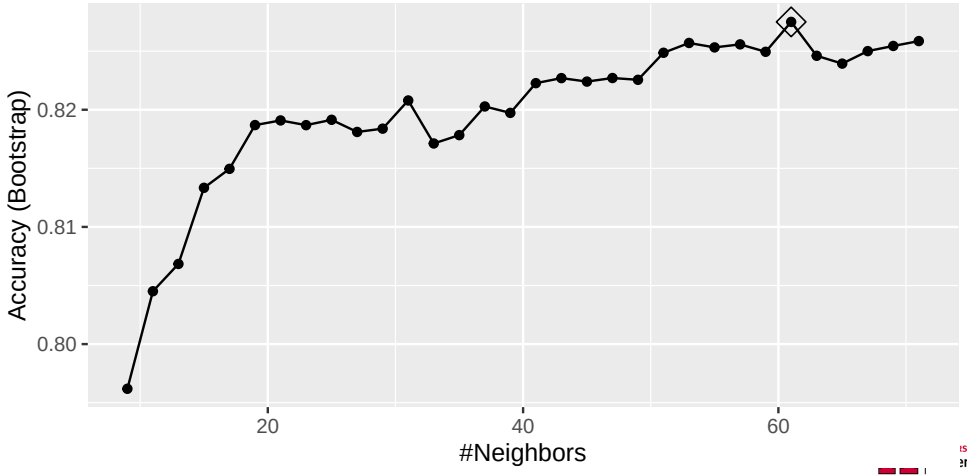
That is $32 \times 25 = 800$ kNN fits.

Cross validation

Cross validation is random, so set the seed for reproducibility:

```
set.seed(2008)
train_knn <- train(y ~ ., method = "knn",
      data = mnist_27$train,
      tuneGrid = data.frame(k = seq(9, 71, 2)))
ggplot(train_knn, highlight = TRUE)
```

Cross validation



Cross validation

The best parameter:

```
train_knn$bestTune
```

```
##     k
## 27 61
```

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and the best model:

```
train_knn$finalModel
```

```
## 61-nearest neighbor model
## Training set outcome distribution:
##
##   2   7
## 401 399
```

Cross validation

`predict` uses the best model. Test-set accuracy (the test set was not used in cross validation):

```
confusionMatrix(predict(train_knn,
                        mnist_27$test, type = "raw"),
                mnist_27$test$y)$overall["Accuracy"]
```

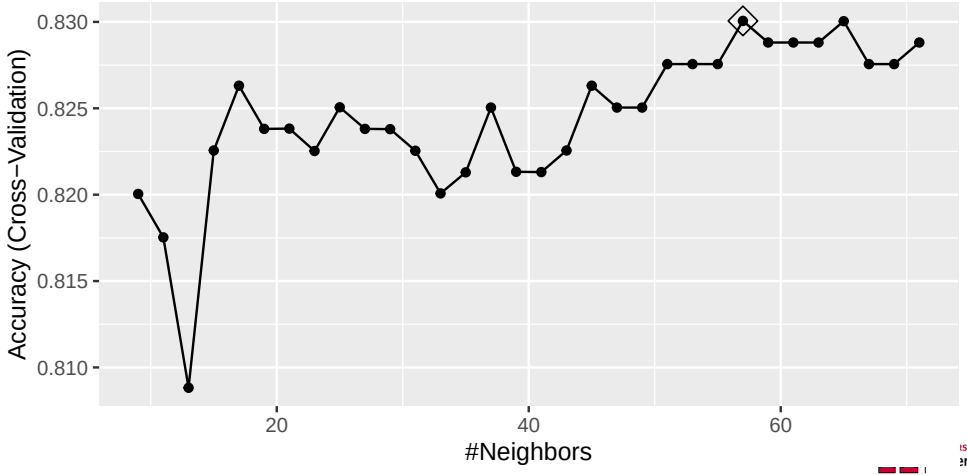
```
## Accuracy
##    0.825
```

Cross validation

`trainControl` changes the CV method; 10-fold is faster than 25 bootstraps:

```
control <- trainControl(method = "cv",
                        number = 10, p = .9)
train_knn_cv <- train(y ~ ., method = "knn",
                      data = mnist_27$train,
                      tuneGrid = data.frame(k = seq(9, 71, 2)),
                      trControl = control)
ggplot(train_knn_cv, highlight = TRUE)
```

Cross validation

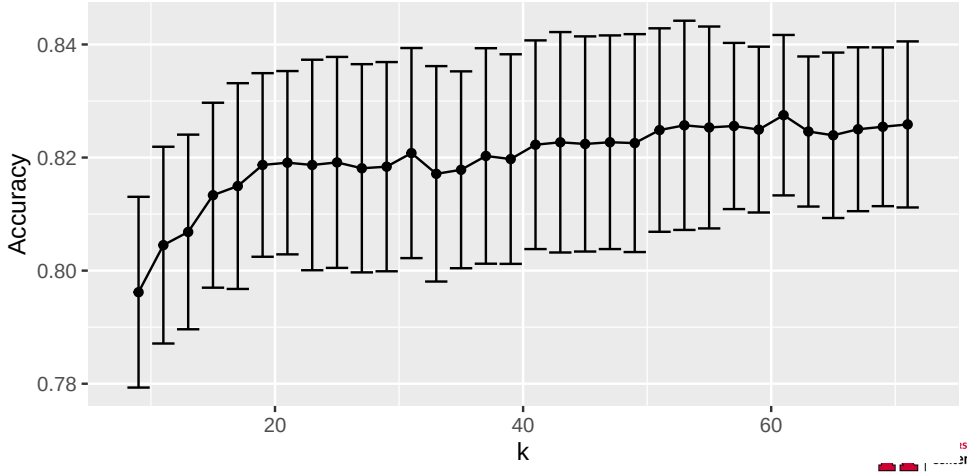


Cross validation

Accuracy with standard deviation bars from the CV samples:

```
train_knn$results %>%
  ggplot(aes(x = k, y = Accuracy)) +
  geom_line() + geom_point() +
  geom_errorbar(aes(x = k,
                    ymin = Accuracy - AccuracySD,
                    ymax = Accuracy + AccuracySD))
```

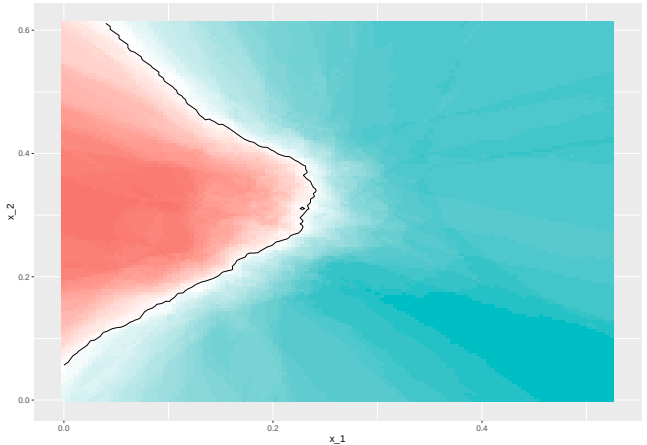
Cross validation



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Example: fitting with loess

The best kNN model approximates the true conditional probability:



Example: fitting with loess

But the boundary is wiggly: kNN, like a bin smoother, uses no kernel. Loess is smoother; in **caret** it is the `gamLoess` method[2], which needs the **gam** package:

```
install.packages("gam")
```

[2] https://topepo.github.io/caret/available-models.html

Example: fitting with loess

It has two tuning parameters:

```
modelLookup("gamLoess")
```

```
##      model parameter  label forReg forClass probModel
## 1 gamLoess      span   Span   TRUE     TRUE      TRUE
## 2 gamLoess    degree Degree   TRUE     TRUE      TRUE
```

We tune `span` and fix `degree = 1` (the grid still needs both columns):

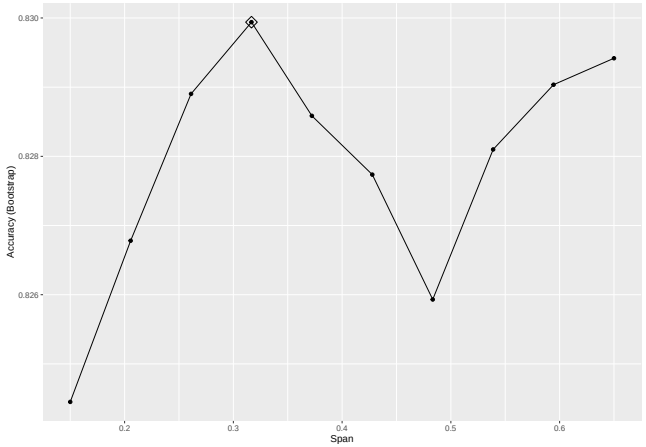
```
grid <- expand.grid(span = seq(0.15, 0.65, len = 10)
                    , degree = 1)
```

Example: fitting with loess

Using the default CV settings:

```
train_loess <- train(y ~ ., method = "gamLoess",
                     tuneGrid=grid,
                     data = mnist_27$train)
ggplot(train_loess, highlight = TRUE)
```

Example: fitting with loess



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Example: fitting with loess

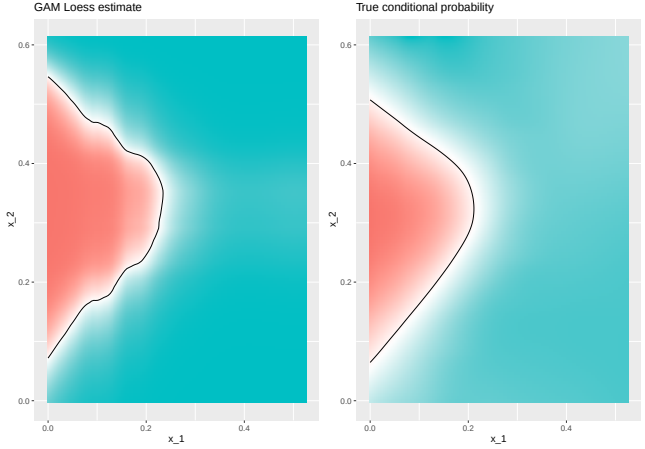
Accuracy is similar to kNN:

```
confusionMatrix(data = predict(
      train_loess, mnist_27$test),
      reference = mnist_27$test$y)$overall["Accuracy"]
```

```
## Accuracy
##     0.83
```

Example: fitting with loess

but the estimate is smoother:



Summary

- Training error is optimistic; we need an honest estimate of test error
- Small k in kNN over-trains; large k over-smooths
- K-fold CV and the bootstrap estimate test error from the training data
- Tune parameters by CV; keep the test set for the final check
- caret's `train` handles resampling and tuning for hundreds of models

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Session Info

```
sessionInfo()
```

```
## R version 4.5.2 (2025-10-31)
## Platform: aarch64-apple-darwin20
## Running under: macOS Tahoe 26.6.2
##
## Matrix products: default
## BLAS:   /System/Library/Frameworks/Accelerate.framework/Versions/A/Frameworks/vecLib.framework/Versions/A/libBLAS.dylib
## LAPACK: /Library/Frameworks/R.framework/Versions/4.5-arm64/Resources/lib/libRlapack.dylib;  LAPACK version 3.12.1
##
## locale:
## [1] en_US.UTF-8/en_US.UTF-8/en_US.UTF-8/C/en_US.UTF-8/en_US.UTF-8
##
## time zone: America/Denver
## tzcode source: internal
##
## attached base packages:
## [1] splines   stats     graphics  grDevices utils     datasets  methods
## [8] base
##
## other attached packages:
##  [1] gridExtra_2.3   dslabs_0.9.1    gam_1.22-7      foreach_1.5.2
##  [5] lubridate_1.9.5 forcats_1.0.1   stringr_1.6.0   dplyr_1.2.1
##  [9] purrr_1.2.2     readr_2.2.0     tidyr_1.3.2     tibble_3.3.1
## [13] tidyverse_2.0.0 caret_7.0-1     lattice_0.22-9  ggplot2_4.0.3
##
## loaded via a namespace (and not attached):
## [1] gtable_0.3.6        xfun_0.58           recipes_1.3.3
```